

Winding Tree



What smart people have to say about travel's recovery and rebound



Spencer · Following

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Turbulence. Both in the sky and on the ground, it's a fact of life. Turbulent times come and go, with some periods more severe than others. Obviously,

with travel hit hard by this global pandemic, the industry is in a particularly rough patch.

Over the past couple of months, we've all been faced with cataclysmic changes and immense impacts that reach far beyond a single industry segment. As our team at Winding Tree recalibrated our own plans — we were supposed to do a major launch at ITB and SXSW — we've looked around the industry for inspiration, context, and color.

One thing we all agree on: The recovery and rebound will happen at different speeds based on geography, segment, and regulation. We all must be patient and strong. Recovery is coming but we have to settle into an arduous, unpredictable journey.

With that said, we've pulled together perspectives from around the industry around recovery strategy, rebound timeline, marketing, communications, and the reshaping of an entire industry. Here are a few of our favorites.

Some quotes have been lightly edited for brevity. [Send over perspectives](#) that have resonated with you and we'll add to enrichen this resource.

On the recovery strategy and rebound timeline

“I am ecstatic to see that vacation rental bookings might soon match pre-COVID levels. We hope this indicates that the industry has turned a corner and that the travel sector as a whole can look forward to a brighter future,”

Scott Shatford, AirDNA CEO

“The biggest challenge we have right now is the complete lack of consistency even within the same city. There are so many nuances airport-by-airport in the same city, never mind country-by-country, where variance gets even wilder and the speed at which things are changing is miraculous.”

Rami El-Dahshan, Virgin Atlantic

“It’s dangerous to change the strategy and direction every week just because you get news about vaccines or not vaccines. Right now it’s important to be principled, and we’re doing that. Our plan predicts basically that 2020 is nonexistent. You cannot have less than zero bookings.”

Tao Tao, GetYourGuide

“Despite a sharp drop in spring travel searches in March, Pinnners are still looking for travel inspiration. In March, searches for summer vacations jumped more than 100% over the previous year. We credit a combination of pent-up demand, time spent cooped up at home and upended spring vacation plans. There’s also been a 59% increase in searches for “places to travel” in the last month vs. the same period last year as people look for inspiration.”

Ashish Arya, Pinterest

“Our data shows travellers are still searching, many booking trips for Q4 2020 and early 2021. APAC has been ahead of the world in their vigilance, so we expect that APAC will be the first region to recover.”

Max Ueno, Sojern

“Collaboration, cooperation and consistency are key, first for the industry to successfully restart, and then for sustaining a balanced recovery.”

Angela Gittens, Airports Council International

“We will see how different strategies that airlines took going into the crisis will play out. For instance, Lufthansa believes they are better prepared to survive something like this because they own their own airplanes, and so don’t have as much debt to service. Time will tell.”

Jon Ostrower, The Air Current

“I feel spectacularly good about the long-term for the industry. We will likely show recovery at a faster pace because we can accommodate types of demand that don’t require air travel. Ultimately, we need the airlines. We need people to get on planes to get to the nirvana which is back to more normal patterns of demand.”

Christopher Nassetta, Hilton

On safety, exposure mitigation and gov’t mandates

“We are asking people to return to a world where the risks are greater, and the challenge is that these are invisible. As a travel manager and employer...we want to ensure that all of the tools, data and information is relevant to their personal needs. Now is the time to talk to each traveler as a human and not apply the same expectations for everyone.”

Matthew Holman, Simpila Healthy Solutions.

“Europe’s citizens can travel safely on their summer holidays wearing face masks and observing temperature protocols. Fourteen day quarantines have no scientific basis, are unimplementable and unnecessary in circumstances where airline, train and underground passengers wear face masks where social distancing isn’t possible.”

Michael O’Leary, Ryanair Group

“Maybe cleaning fees are the new resort fees.”

Jan Freitag, STR

“While airlines should seek to maintain physical distancing where practicable, flexibility on seating arrangements is permitted. And quarantine requirements are not necessary. It is absolutely essential that all European states apply these

guidelines in a harmonized and mutually recognized way. Local deviations and exceptions will damage public confidence and make it harder to operate effectively. This would be harmful to public health and the economic recovery.”

Rafael Schwartzman, IATA

“No buffets, no minibars. We’re going to walk into the hotel, go up the elevator by myself, enter my room without having to touch anything with some comfort that the service provider has completely disinfected that space prior to my arrival.”

Christopher Anderson, Cornell Hotel School

“It’s not realistic for hotels across the spectrum to have extreme measures of mitigation. And so, [travel managers] have to say, these hotels that don’t have those capabilities or resources, What is our risk appetite? What is our duty of care to our employees and to our guests?”

Dr. Robert Quigley, International SOS

On marketing, revenue, and pricing

“We have not done our job on a couple of fronts as our own brands competed...we were creating our own dynamics in the marketplace we never fully understood. [Now] we have the opportunity for an entire reset because we’ve essentially gone to zero marketing.. We can watch and learn...and not just dive back in headfirst and spend at the levels we were at.”

Peter Kern, Expedia Group

“Take this opportunity to shift your marketing focus further back in the decision-making process — to the all-important inspiration phase. For example, shift ‘One-way flights to Hawaii’ to ‘Beach dreaming? Plan a future trip to Honolulu.’”

Ashish Arya, Pinterest

“All airlines, hotels and others will need to adapt quickly in terms of how they do revenue management and pricing. We’re all looking to how we innovate during this period to change some of the standards we’ve known for perhaps 40/50 years.”

Rami El-Dahshan, Virgin Atlantic

“Go back to the basics of true one-to-one connecting. That means calling our past clients, checking in with them, emailing, snail mail. After all, it is so rare these days to receive a card in the mail.”

Vicki Freed, Royal Caribbean International

“Our recommended strategy is not a blanket strategy and more geographically targeted since countries are in different stages of lockdown or recovery. There are signs of life returning to normal in China. Now they want relaxing lifestyle content to get travel inspirations, to dream for trips they wish to take when it is all safe to travel.”

Anita Chan, Compass Edge

“What matters in a time like this with very little volume is not paying less on a booking. It’s actually getting bookings.”

Cyril Ranque, Expedia Group

“The travel industry will undergo a fundamental reset. Truly global intermediaries like Booking.com or Airbnb that do not have a high dependency on any single geography and can quickly and opportunistically redirect its business to the most promising geographies are better positioned to adapt than other OTAs that are more reliant on a particular country or region.”

Mario Gavira, investor

On communicating with travelers

“Airlines and TMCs are going to have to be more comfortable being agile in saying ‘such and such country is open now and if we get stuck there, this is how we’ll get you home.’”

Rami El-Dahshan, Virgin Atlantic

“Connecting with customers during the darkest moments of the crisis will turn out to be the most powerful loyalty program. Speedy refunds for cancelled bookings, rebookings for clients stranded overseas and an ongoing and candid communication strategy will win hearts and pockets.”

Mario Gavira, investor

“Brands must stay in sync with the emotions and mindsets of their guests and partners. This doesn’t necessitate a change in strategy or philosophy but does require us to think differently in our approach in how we consistently communicate the right message at the right time.”

James Rodriguez, Oceania Cruises

“We’re doing live yoga classes via Instagram. We’re doing chocolate making. We’ve got a magician doing shows. We’re doing horses that swim in the sea. If we can find a way of filling the void of bringing some happiness to those that know and support us, then we’re going to do it. That’s how you stay top of mind.”

James McBride, Indonesia’s Nihi Sumba resort

On (re)building trust with travelers

“Until we rebuild the trust in travel, in the consumer’s eyes, that it’s safe, we’re not going to move very far. We need to communicate to customers what the industry is doing as far as health and safety matters.”

Cyril Ranque, Expedia Group

“The common denominator in all these passenger confidence challenges is information. Getting relevant, accurate, and timely information to different passenger types in a language they understand by a channel they are listening to is the only way to build back this confidence. If you get the personalization, accuracy and timing right, there’s no such thing as over-communicating.”

Nick Key, 15Below

“Travelers will be looking for brands marketing in channels they trust, and ensuring they’ll be safe in the physical world. The combination creates a positive association that will help reassure people that they can get back out there with confidence.”

Ashish Arya, Pinterest

“The worst thing a travel brand can do is to create any extra hysteria and ruin any chance they have of coming back later in the year. Demonstrating stability and consistency as this pandemic is sorted out is probably one of the best things that can be done.”

Yuan Oscar Yuan, Strategy3

On startups and angel investing

“The biggest variable in underwriting an investment today is time,” Hemmeter said. “It’s really, really hard to figure out how much money companies will need to reach milestones and when those milestones might occur.”

Chris Hemmeter, Thayer Ventures

On how things have changed (or not)

“If social touch becomes even more rare post-coronavirus, spas may provide a unique haven where people can experience touch in a clean and safe

environment.”

Jeremy McCarthy, Mandarin Oriental

“People will travel. People will book experiences. The long-term vision has not changed. This is a \$100 billion-plus market, not very much online penetration.”

Tao Tao, GetYourGuide

“Global travel may be some time away from now but we are confident to seize every opportunity, starting with local experiences. What we do now will define how we navigate the future of travel.”

Eric Gnock Fah, Klook

“We are still facing an unpredictable road in the remainder of the year, and will not meet our original 2020 targets. But we are alive and kicking and are more ambitious than we ever were, seeing a great chance to make the hotel market much more efficient for travellers the world over.”

Oz Har Adir, FindHotel

“Wanderlust in all its forms is going to be the fast pass to finding our way back to the world again, and back to the people — from the family-owned restaurant chefs to the drivers, hotel concierges, locals, and guides — who make travel so worthwhile.”

Tom Marchant, Black Tomato

“This trend towards Asia-like super apps in the Western World will spark a frenzy post-crisis, with merger activity between travel tech giants and mobility and food delivery tech players, whose valuations suffered a massive downward correction due to their weak balance sheets.”

Mario Gavira, investor

“The crisis is accelerating existing trends. It’s accelerating consolidation that would have happened anyway. It consolidated the need for mature businesses to have more than one core value proposition. It’s also a huge opportunity to reset everything.”

Alex Hefer, CEO Trivago

“This demand shock is going to lead to an accelerated process of experimentation, where suppliers look for ways to become more flexible and cost-efficient thanks to automation.”

Chris Hemmeter, Thayer Ventures

On sustainability

“Our goal is to trigger a renaissance of the city. We want to attract visitors for longer stays and encourage a ‘slower’ type of tourism. Things can’t go back to how they were.”

Paola Mar, Venice’s councillor for tourism

“Of course, it’s completely devastating — but it’s also provided a much-needed chance for introspection. Things needed to change. It’s an opportunity for everyone from tourist boards to tour operators to reset and to look at how things can be better — for the planet, for local communities and for travellers.”

Sam Bruce of Much Better Adventures

“We are working with partners to discuss how we can restart in a more sustainable and responsible way. We want a sustainable visitor economy that doesn’t harm livability. If you have the right balance between living, working and visiting, you can have the right visitor economy.”

Heleen Jansen, Amsterdam&Partners

“In the short term, our customers and employees need to be reassured, with reinforced hygiene control processes. Also, we expect customers to want more LOCAL: buy products locally made, eat local food, travel domestically...We shouldn’t forbid ourselves to be optimistic, as this crisis will also generate lots of opportunities.”

Alex Sogno, Global Asset Solutions

“This is a short-term problem, and we are in a long-term business.”

Pamela Hoffee, Avalon Waterways

“Our goal is to thrive. The imperative here is to survive.”

Gary Kelly, Southwest Airlines

What other quotes and words of wisdom have resonated with you? Contribute your favorite perspectives and we’ll add to this resource.

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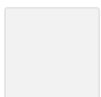
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